

CHAPTER XI

Egalitarian Society

The character and development of the Sikh movement reveals that it had three main social goals: (1) to build up an egalitarian society, (2) to use this new society as a base to wage an armed struggle against religious and political oppression, and (3) to capture political power by the Khalsa. All these aims were integral parts of the Sikh thesis that injustice, inequality and hierarchism, in whatsoever form, must be combated. In this chapter we shall deal with the first goal.

1. The Caste

The caste system was the greatest obstacle in the way of the Sikh movement for developing an egalitarian society. Though the Sikh Gurus had no soft corner for the lesser variations of social inequities, they felt that, unless the fundamental menace of the caste was eliminated, there could be no major change in the other inequities. We shall, therefore, concentrate on the egalitarian social aspect of the movement mainly in its relevancy to the caste. It is important that the struggle of the Sikh movement against the caste should be judged in the context of its observance in the medieval era, and not under the present day conditions when it is losing its old hold and sting.

The Radical Bhaktas denounced the pillars on which the super structure of the caste system rested. The Sikh Gurus did this even more unequivocally. To avoid repetition, we shall deal with only the broad aspects of the caste and the practical steps taken by the Sikh movement to combat this evil.

a) Motivating Power

The motivation which sustains a social system is more important than the means employed to achieve its objectives. Consequently, a movement which aims at abolishing a social system, has, while not losing sight of the means, to concentrate on subverting the motivating power of the old system. To weaken the values on which a social system stands is to weaken the foundations of a system are more important than its features. Unless this is kept in view, one is likely to lose the right perspective in assessing the strength of any attack on the caste system.

The directive force underlying the Indian social and religious development was, on the whole, the preservation of the caste order. The motivating power behind the caste system was the upholding of the caste status of the Brahmins and the high castes. This is the key to the understanding of the caste system, and, consequently, to the appreciation of the anti-caste movements. Restrictions on connubium, commensalism and occupations on castes, and the ritual barriers between them, were all contributory means for achieving the main aim of maintaining the caste-status.

b) Caste-status

The caste was essentially a social rank, but it gave social status a new content by giving it a religious and ritualistic significance. 'The ties of caste', writes Sherring, 'are stronger than those of religion... With many Hindus the highest form of religious observance is the complete fulfilment of the claims of caste; and most of them conceive of sin as a breach of castes discipline rather than of moral law.'¹ Markandeya Purana lays down that perfection can only be attained by the man who does not deviate from the duties of caste.² That is why we have termed social rank of the caste order as 'caste-status' in order to distinguish it from social rank in class societies. Social phenomenon cannot be explained in absolute terms, especially when forces opposed to each other are simultaneously at work. But, by and large, caste-status was given preference over economic and political considerations. When a king and a Brahmin pass along the same road, the road belongs to the Brahmin and

not to the king. ^{2a} Between a hundred year old Kshatriya and a ten year old Brahmin, the latter is said to be like father. ^{2b} The king must show himself first in the morning to the Brahmins and salute them. ^{2c} “The visas (clans) bow spontaneously to the chief (rajan), who is preceded by a Brahmin.”³ The poorest Brahmin was superior in caste rank to the wealthiest Bania. The arca (respect) due to a Brahmin, or atleast the Brahmin’s claim to respect, was higher than a King’s.⁴ Legitimation of political power was powerful lever in the hands of the Brahmins, because political upstarts hankered after the legitimation of their status in the caste hierarchy. This legitimation secured for the dominant political castes a superiority over their subjects ‘with an efficiency unsurpassed by any other religion’.⁵ This is how the barbarian warrior castes and the Rajputs accepted Brahmanical superiority. One of the reasons why Buddhism was vanquished was that it failed to provide such a legitimation to the ruling classes. It is not for nothing that the Maratha leader Shivaji went about abegging, even when Hindu power was at a low ebb, for the legitimation of his caste rank.

c) Status-consciousness, Caste and the Sikh movement

Sikhism is opposed to status consciousness in all its forms, because it regards ‘I’ consciousness (ego) as the greatest hurdle in the way of man’s moral and spiritual progress:

“He, alone is supreme among beings,
Whose ego goeth in the society of the Holy.
He, who thinks himself to be the lowest of the lowly,
Yea, he alone is the highest of the high.
He, whose mind is the dust of all,
O, he alone worshipeth the Lord in his heart.”⁶

The Indian orthodox religious tradition, too, has emphasized the need for eliminating ego (Ahankara); but, at the same time, it saw no contradiction in sanctifying the caste system (Varna Ashrama Dharma), which involves inequity and hierarchism. In order to reconcile this contradiction, the orthodox tradition compartmentalised ethics by setting different standards in ethical behaviour for the individual and the society. There is no such

dichotomy in Sikhism. In Sikhism, social and individual problems cannot be divorced from each other. Both have to be tackled together by a single religious approach. Sikhism did not content itself by merely attacking status consciousness in general terms. It condemned it in its direct relationship to the caste. It unequivocally declares: "O foolish man, don't take pride in caste-status; this pride leads to many an evil."⁷ "Religion consisteth not in mere words; he who looks upon all men as equals, is religious."⁸ Some of the Radical Bhaktas also subscribed in theory to the same thesis. They condemned the divisive values of the caste system. But, it is the Sikh movement alone which, impelled by its integrated religious approach to life, proceeded to make its thesis a social reality. The condemnation of status consciousness has been related to the undoing of the caste and the building of a casteless egalitarian society.

Guru Nanak attacked the caste ideology and called it perverse. "According to the Hindus, foul is the ablution of the Chandal, and vain are his religious ceremonies and decorations. False is the wisdom of the perverse; they acts produce strife. In the impure man is pride; he obtaineth not the favour of the Lord."⁹ Further, he aligned himself with the lowliest of the low castes. "There are lower castes among the low castes and some absolutely low. Nanak seeketh their company. What hath he to do with the high ones? For, where the lowly are cared for, there is thine (God's) Benediction and Grace."¹⁰

Bhai Gurdas was born twelve years after Guru Nanak's death. He joined the Sikh mission at a very early age. When Guru Amardas established twenty-two Manjis or dioceses, he was put in charge of the dioceses of Agra. Guru Arjan entrusted Bhai Gurdas with the duty of writing the Guru Granth at his (Guru's) dictation. On the death of Bhai Buddha, he was appointed as the head priest of the premier Sikh temple, Hari Mandir. Therefore, the writings of Bhai Gurdas are equally valuable and an authentic source of the Sikh tradition. He writes that Guru Nanak "made the Dharma perfect by blending the four castes into one. To treat the king and the pauper on equal footing, and while greeting to touch the feet of the other (i.e. to regard oneself humble as compared to others), was made the rule of conduct."¹¹ These lines unambiguously record, in the context of the

times, a major achievement of Guru Nanak. He did away with not only caste-status consciousness but also with the status-consciousness gap between the rich and the poor. For, far from observing untouchability, everyone actually touched the feet of everyone else while greeting him. The language used the Bhai Gurdas makes it clear that he was not repeating a precept enunciated by the Guru in his hymns, but a precept practised by his followers. Again, "The four castes were made into one, and castes (Varn) and out-caste (Avarn) regarded as noble;... The twelve sects were obliterated and the noble glorious Panth (created)."¹² Here the abolition of caste and sects is linked with the creation of the Sikh Panth. In order to emphasise its significance, Bhai Gurdas repeatedly mentions this achievement. For the same idea is conveyed at other places too.¹³ His stress is doubly evident, for he contrasts this achievement with the then prevailing social milieu in which, he felt, the society (Jagat) had been vitiated by the creation of the caste system (Varn Ashram).¹⁴ All this shows that from the very start, one of Guru Nanak's social goals was to establish the Sikh Panth with a view to creating an egalitarian society.

The Janamsakhis also corroborate the above view. The very first and the constant companion of Guru Nanak during his missionary tours was Mardana. He was doubly unacceptable to the caste society, because he was a Muslim and of a very low caste (Mirasi). "Mardana told Guru Nanak that by his (the Guru's) grace, his (Mardana's) ego had disappeared and that the four castes were due to that ego." On a missionary tour in the North, one of the Guru's companions was a calico-printer (Chimba) and another a black-smith (Lohar).¹⁵ Both of these Sudra castes are rated quite low in the caste hierarchy. Again, Guru Nanak accepted the invitation of a poor and low caste Lalo and spurned that of the rich landlord, Malik Bhago.¹⁶ All through his life, people of all castes, including Sudras and Muslims, would unhesitatingly come to him for solace.¹⁷ He told Salis Ray that this salvation lay in prostrating before his own slave.¹⁸ When questioned as to his caste, he said he was without caste (Ajati), or that his caste was as that of God (Nirankari).¹⁹ At another place, he identified himself with the weavers.²⁰ He appointed

Jhanda, a carpenter, as his deputy to spread his mission.²¹

The second Guru holds the Vedas directly responsible for initiating the myth of high and low castes and thus misleading the people. “The Vedas have given currency to the myths that make men reflect upon (Human values of) good and evil... The sense of high and low, and of caste and colour; such are the illusions created in men...”²² There was no place in his congregation for any one who observed caste.²³ All the castes were treated as equals.²⁴ Only those who were not afraid of Vedic and caste injunctions came to his congregation; others did not.²⁵ At the Langar (free kitchen) all sat at the same platform and took the same food.²⁶ The third Guru Amar Das went a step further. No one who had not partaken of food at his Langar could see him.²⁷ In his langar, “there were no distinctions of caste. Lines of noble Gurbhais (disciples of the same Guru) partook of food sitting together at the same place.”²⁸ The Hindus complained to Emperor Akbar that the Guru had abolished the distinction among the four castes. ‘He seateth all his followers in a line and causeth them to eat together from his kitchen, irrespective of caste whether they are Jats, minstrels, Muhammadans, Brahmins, Khatries, shop-keepers, sweepers, barbers, washermen, fishermen, or carpenters.’²⁹ The Hindu governor of Kasur refused Guru Amardas the facility of pitching his tent in the governor’s garden, saying : “He hath attached to him men of all castes, high and low. They sit in a line and eat with him and with one another. If he chooses to be a Guru of outcastes, he can please himself, but I will not allow him to approach my dwelling.”³⁰ Guru Arjan told Sandhu (Budhu), the potter, that it was Guru Nanak who had introduced common commensality among the four castes.³¹ Guru Hargobind ‘joined the four castes to make them one.’³² He put one cobbler (Chamar) in charge of a memorial-shrine (Damdama) he built.³³ The same Guru told Bhai Bidhia that Rup Chand (who had come from the carpenter caste) was very dear to him:

“He should be seated at a high pedestal, so that men and women should show reverence to him... He held his (Rup Chand’s) arm and seated him there;

The Guru anointed him with his own hands.”³⁴

Guru Gobind Singh chose five Beloved ones (Panj Piaras) as the leaders of the Khalsa community. Of them one was a jat, one a barber, one a calico-printer and one a water-carrier.³⁵ The three last were Sudra, the Jat being on the borderline of Vaisyas and Sudras. At the time of the baptism (Amrit) ceremony, the Guru enjoined on all who had joined the Khalsa that they should consider their previous castes erased and deem themselves all brothers i.e. of one family.³⁶ The newswriter of the period sent the Emperor a copy of the Guru's address to his Sikhs on that occasion. It is dated the first of Baisakhi 1756 (A.D. 1699), and runs as follows: ‘Let all embrace one creed and obliterate differences of religion. Let the four Hindu castes who have different rules for their guidance abandon them all, adopt the one form of adoration and become brothers. Let no one deem himself superior to others... Let men of the four castes receive my baptism, eat out of one dish, and feel no disgust or contempt for one another.’³⁷ These may or may not be the exact words of the Guru's address, but their substance is corroborated by the near-contemporary Koer Singh. He records that the Guru said: ‘Many a Vaish (Vaishya), Sudar (Shudra) and Jat have I incorporated in the Panth,’³⁸ Again, he writes that the Guru ‘has made the four castes into a single one, and made the Sudra, Vaish, Khatri and Brahmin take meals at the same place’.³⁹ In the later literature, too, it has been recorded that the Guru's mission was to weld the four castes into one. ‘Any one of the four castes who takes baptism assumed my (the Guru's) form’.⁴⁰

All the members of the Khalsa Dal, who were drawn from all castes including the Rangretas, dined together.⁴¹ One of the leading warriors in the battle of Chamkaur was Jiwan Singh, Rangreta.⁴² The supreme commander of the Sikh Panth, who succeeded Nawab Kapur Singh and who later struck coin in the name of the Sikh Panth at Lahore, was Jassa Singh Ahluwalia. He had been converted from the distiller caste (Kalal), a low caste despised for the land as a confederacy, one of its twelve units was headed by Jassa Singh Ramgharia, a carpenter. Another derived from

the same caste, Sukha Singh, was the leader of the Khalsa in that great battle called Chota Ghalu Ghara.

d) The spirit of equality, brotherhood and fraternization

In assessing the anti-caste stance of the Sikh movement, what is even more important is the spirit of equality, brotherhood and fraternization that pervaded it during the Khalsa period, because, more than the form, it is the spirit which reflects the character of a movement.

The idea of equality was inherent in the system of the Gurus and the Sikh movement so long it retained its pristine purity. After he had anointed Angad as his successor, Guru Nanak bowed at his feet in salutation. The same custom was followed by the later Gurus.⁴³ The Sikhs, who had imbibed the spirit of the Gurus, were regarded as equals of the Guru. The collective wisdom of the congregation of Sikhs was of higher value than that of the Guru alone (Guru weeh visve, sangat iki visve). Bhai Gurdas repeatedly makes it clear that there was no status gap between the Guru and a Sikh (Gur chela, chela Guru).⁴⁴ Guru Angad was very much displeased with the minstrels (Rabibis) who refused to comply with a request from Bhai Buddha. The Guru said : 'Regard the Guru's Sikh as myself; have no doubt about this'.⁴⁵ Guru Hargobind, out of reverence for Bhai Buddha, a devout Sikh, touched his feet.⁴⁶ He told Bhai Bidhichand that there was no difference between him and the Guru.⁴⁷ The same Guru reprimanded the members of his own family for not sharing sweets with his Sikhs, who, he said 'were dearer to him than his life'.⁴⁸ The Sikhs addressed each other as 'brother' (Bhai), thus showing a perfect level of equality among them. In all the available letters written by the Gurus the Sikhs have been addressed as brothers (Bhai).⁴⁹ It was in continuation of this tradition that Guru Gobind Singh requested with clasped hands the Beloved ones to baptise him.⁵⁰ This shows that he regarded them not only as his equal but made them as his Guru. This was the utmost limit to which a religious head could conceive of or practise human equality.

The spirit of brotherhood and fraternization is even more difficult to inculcate than the spirit of equality. This new spirit was a natural

sequence of the Sikh doctrines and approach. What is important is the emphasis laid on this spirit of brotherhood and fraternization in the Sikh literature, and more particularly the extent to which it was practised by the Sikh movement.

As there was no difference between the Guru and the Sikh; the devotion to the Guru was easily channelized into the service of the Sikhs. 'God-oriented service is the service of the Guru's Sikhs, who should be regarded as one's dearest kith and kin'⁵¹ 'The Guru's Sikhs should serve the other Sikhs.'⁵² 'The (sixth) Guru said:' 'The Sikhs are dearer to me than life.'⁵³ One of Guru Gobind Singh's own hymns is:

"To serve them pleaseth my heart; no other service is dear to my soul.

.....

All the wealth of my house with my soul and body is for them."⁵⁴

The codes of Sikh conduct (Rehatnamas) continue to record this tradition. 'He who shirks a poor man is an absolute defaulter.'⁵⁵ 'Serve a Sikh and a pauper'.⁵⁶ 'If some among a group of Sikhs sleep on cots and the poor Sikhs sleep on the floor and are not shown due courtesy, the former Sikhs are at fault.'⁵⁷ 'The essence of Sikhism is service, love and devotion... (The Sikh) should be regarded as the image of the Guru and served as such.'⁵⁸

Bhalla records that these precepts were actually followed in the Sikh panth. 'The Sikhs served each other, regarding every Sikh as the Guru's image.'⁵⁹ Bhangu writes: 'No body bore malice to any one; the Singhs (Sikhs who had been baptized) vied with each other in rendering service to others.'⁶⁰ 'If any Sikh got or brought any eatable, it was never used alone, it was partaken by all the Sikhs. Nothing was hidden from the other Sikhs. All eatable were shared by all members of the Khalsa; if there was nothing to eat, they would say 'The Langar is in trance (Masat)'. 'One would offer food to others first and then eat oneself. Singhs would be addressed with great love.'⁶¹ 'Guru's Sikh was the brother of each Sikh.'⁶² During the days of struggle with the Mughals, one Niranjania reported to the Mughal governor against the

Sikhs: "They would themselves go hungry and naked, but would not bear the misery of the Singhs; they themselves would ward off cold by sitting near fire, but would send clothes to the Singhs; they would grind corn with their own hands and send it to the Singhs; they would twist ropes and send its proceeds to the Singhs. They, who for their living would go to far off places, send their earnings to the Singhs.⁶³ "All members of the Khalsa Dal 'were issued clothes from a common store. Without concealing anything, they would pool all their earnings at one place. If any one found or brought any valuable, these were deposited in the treasury as common property."⁶⁴

The prevalence of this spirit of equality, brotherhood and fraternization among the Sikhs is confirmed by evidence from the non-Sikh sources. Ghulam mohyy-ud-Din, the author of *Fatuhat Namah-I-Samadi* (1722-23), was a contemporary of Banda. He writes that low-caste Hindus, termed *Khas-o-Khashak-I-hamid-I-jahanmi wajud* (i.e. the dregs of the society of the hellish Hindus) swelled the ranks of Banda, and everyone in his army 'would address the other as the adopted son of the oppressed Guru (Guru Gobind Singh) and would publicise themselves with the title of *sahibzada* ("Yaki ra b targhib-I-digran pisaar-I-khanda-I-guru-I-maqhur gufta b laqub-I-shahzadgi mashur kardah").^{64a} A contemporary historian of Aurangzeb writers, "if a stranger knocks at their door (i.e. the door of Sikhs) at midnight and utters the name of Nanak, though he may be a thief, robber or wretch, he is considered a friend and brother, and is properly looked after.'⁶⁵ Mir Ghulam Hussain Khan writes (1783 A.D.) about the Khalsa Panth, "When a person is once admitted into that fraternity, they make no scruple of associating with him, of whatever tribe, clan, or race he may have been hitherto; nor do they betray any of those scruples and prejudices so deeply rooted in the Hindu mind.'⁶⁶ Commenting on the last part of the statement, the editor says, "This alludes to the touching or eating with persons of impure castes, in regard to which the Hindus are so tenacious.'⁶⁷ The author of *Haqiqat* also writes about the same time that 'the Sikh were told: "Whoever might join you from whichever tribe, don't have any prejudice against him and without any superstition eat together with him." *Now this is their custom,*'^{67a}

Here we have good independent testimony from two sources that upto 1783, at least, the Sikhs drawn from all castes dined freely with each other. The Haqiqat clearly states that Khatris, Jats, Carpenters, blacksmiths and grain grocers all joined the Khalsa^{a67b} and '*now this is their custom*'.

The significance of the spirit of equality, brotherhood and fraternization achieved by the Sikh movement can be realized only if it is contrasted with the caste background in which the change was brought about. Bougle observes: "The spirit of caste unites these three tendencies, repulsion, hierarchy and hereditary specialization... We say that a society is characterized by such a system if it is divided into a large number of mutually opposed groups which are hereditary specialised and hierarchically arranged — if, on principle, it tolerates neither the parvenu, nor miscegenation, nor a change of profession."⁶⁸ 'From the social and political point of view, caste is division, hatred, jealousy and distrust between neighbour'.⁶⁹ Nesafeld also comes to the conclusion that the caste system leads to a degree of social disunion to which no parallel can be found in human history. All authorities on caste are agreed that mutual repulsion and disunity, besides inequality and hierarchism, are the in-built constituents of the caste system.

e) *Pollution*

The most wide-spread expression of the mutual repulsion and disunion of the caste society were the restrictions on commensalism and the notions of pollution. It is an indisputable fact that the taboo on food and drink was its most widely practised feature which invited severe penalties. Of the offences of which a caste Panchayat took cognizance, the "Offences against the commensal taboos, which prevent members of the caste from eating, drinking, or smoking with members of another caste, or atleast of other castes regarded by the prohibiting caste as lower in social status than themselves, are undoubtedly the most important; for the transgression by one member of the caste if unknown and unpunished may affect the whole caste with pollution through his commensality with the rest."⁷⁰ 'If the member of low caste merely looks at the meal of a Brahmin, it ritually defiles the Brahmin,'⁷¹ and 'a stranger's shadow, or even the

glance of a man of low caste, falling on the cooking pot may necessitate throwing away the contents.’⁷² There are Indian proverbs that ‘three Kanaujias require no less than thirteen hearths’⁷³, and that a ‘Bisnoi mounted on a camel followed by a score more will immediately throw away his food if a man of another caste happens to touch the last animals.’⁷⁴ These proverbs may partly be exaggerations, but these do illustrate the extent to which the taboos on food had taken hold of the Indian life.

All the transgressions of the taboos on food and drink were always punished, because, as noted above, not to punish these affected the whole caste with pollution. In some cases, the consequences were quite serious and permanent. ‘A separate lower caste (the Kallars) has arisen in Bengal among people who had infringed the ritual and dietary laws during the famine of 1866, and in consequence been excommunicated.’⁷⁵

Underlying the taboos on foods and drinks was the general notion of pollution which was very wide in its sphere of application. Because, it was supposed to be incurred not only by partaking of food and drinks under certain conditions, but by the mere bodily contact with persons of ‘certain low castes, whose traditional occupation, whether actually followed or not, or whose mode of life places them outside the pale of Hindu society’.⁷⁶ Sweeper castes (from which Rangretas came) were one of these. “According to Barbosa, a Nayar woman touched by a Pulayan is outcaste for life and thinks only of leaving her home for fear of polluting her family.”⁷⁷ This is, of course, an extreme case. ‘Castes lower than a Brahmin are generally speaking less easily defiled, but the principle is the same, and contact with caste or outcastes of this category used to entail early steps to remove the pollution.’⁷⁸

Viewed against this background, the degree of social equality, brotherhood and fraternization achieved in the Sikh Panth was indeed, remarkable. And of this there is no doubt that the Panth comprised people drawn from all castes, including the lowest ones. We have already referred to the testimony of the Janamsakhies. Bhai Gurdas, in his eleventh Var, has given the names of some of the important Sikhs during the period of the first six Gurus. The list includes members drawn from all

castes ranging from Brahmins to Chandals (the lowest caste). Irvine writes: 'After the Khatri and the jat peasants, the most noticeable components of the Sikh body are the lower caste artisans and men of the outcaste or menial tribes. This fact attracted the notice of the Muhammadan writers, as we see in our account, taken from them of the disturbances following on the death of Guru Gobind Singh. Recent enquiries bear this out. In the census of 1881, nine out of every hundred Sikhs were of the outcaste scavenger and leather-dresser races, and the other thirteen were of the artisan class, one half of these being carpenters. On the other hand, there were only four Brahmins in every thousand.'⁷⁹

Irvine's figures gain added meaning if one agrees with the contemporary statement of Hugel, that it is only of late and with great difficulty that the Maharaja (Ranjit Singh) has been able to persuade some of the descendants of the higher castes to embrace the Sikh faith, and we shall show further how much trouble this has occasioned him'.⁸⁰ Polier wrote (1780 A.D.) that 'the Siques then began to increase greatly in number...; all that came, though from the lowest and most abject castes, were received contrary to the Hindu customs which admit of no change of caste, and even Mussalmans were in the number of converts.'⁸¹ Griffiths (1794) tells us that 'the Seiks receive Proselytes of almost every Caste, a point in which they differ most materially from the Hindoos'.⁸² The German Hugel describes the Sikhs of the time as 'the descendants from all the lowest castes of Hindus, from which they have been proselyted.'⁸³ These early accounts of the Europeans are all the more valuable, because, as already pointed out, these deal with the times of the Misals and Ranjit Singh, when the Sikh revolution had receded.

The participation of people derived from all castes in the revolutionary struggle further cemented among them the spirit of comradeship and fraternization. It was a cohesion sealed with the stamp of blood. Moreover, the Sikhs were inspired by a common cause, the cause of capturing power for the Khalsa. And, the Khalsa was constituted of people drawn from all castes, especially from the lower ones. No long-drawn-out guerilla warfare could be carried on without an ideological inspiration or without a deep commitment to mutual comradeship.

2. Inter-caste Marriages

It has been said that the Sikh movement did not do much to promote inter-caste marriages. This assertion has probably been made in order to detract from the anti-caste achievements of the movement. It appears that the role of endogamy** in the caste complex has either not been understood, or has been overemphasized.⁸⁴

i) *Endogamy and the caste complex*

Hutton writes: 'Indeed, it seems possible that caste endogamy is more or less incidental to the taboo on taking food cooked by a person of at any rate a lower, if not of any other caste, and in the view of the writer this taboo is probably the keystone of the whole system. It is not uncommon in some parts of India for a man of one caste to keep a concubine of a lower caste, or even a non-Hindu, and he is not outcast by his caste fellows on that ground, though he may be, and often is, on the ground that he has eaten food cooked or served by her or taken water from her hands. This suggests that the taboo on marriage is the necessary and inevitable outcome of the taboo on food and drink, rather than the cause of it.'⁸⁵ Hutton thus underscores the point that the problem of endogamy is only a part of the caste complex, and not an independent or a premier part at that. As such, its role should be viewed in this context and in the right perspective. The removal of endogamy is not indispensable for breaking up the caste structure. For, the caste has been losing its hold in India since it came in contact with the Western culture and the capitalist economy. But, all the same, not many inter-caste marriages have taken place since then so as to make any appreciable contribution to this development.

What is fundamental to the caste system is the preservation of the caste status, and the ritualistic and religious sanction which helped maintain that status. The restrictions on inter-caste marriages are made inflexible by the religious and ritualistic rules of the caste ideology. 'Among classes who marry among them-

selves, marriage outside the class is prevented by sentiment and not by hard and fast rules. Marriage outside the class in Europe might be rare and invalid, but in India, if it is contracted outside the caste, it is a sacrilege.’⁸⁶

What makes endogamy formidable and obnoxious in the caste are not prevented, as in class societies, primarily by sentiment, but by the ‘hard and fast’ rules of the caste ideology. These ‘hard and fast’ rules are not applicable exclusively to endogamy. Most of these rules, especially the social approach underlying them, cover in their ramifications almost the entire spectrum of caste mechanism. For example, caste endogamy is the product of the notion that Aryan blood is pure and the non-Aryan impure, and that the admixture of the two should be avoided. As the mixture of the Aryan and non-Aryan bloods had already taken place on a large scale, caste endogamy was enforced at a later state to compartmentalize this mixture so as to prevent further admixture. Exactly, the same principle or notion about the purity of Aryan blood and the impurity of non-Aryan blood underlies the injunctions against inter-dining among castes and pollution by contact or sight. “Despite their indispensability for a millenium, the impure castes have remained absolutely impure; because of the blood they inherit which could not be accepted as pure under any circumstances. All such people are magically defiled.’ ‘Their very presence may infect the air of a room and so defile food in its that it must be thrown away to prevent evil enchantment.’⁸⁷ The idea that certain persons defile if they sit down to a meal in one row is present in the Sutas.⁸⁸ Similarly, Gautma upholds that an impure person imparts pollution by his touch and even by his near approach.⁸⁹ In the later periods, these rules were further elaborated and made rigid. In the medieval Occident, ““here were factual barriers restricting the connubium between differently esteemed occupations, but there were not ritual barriers, such as are absolutely essential for caste. Within the circle of the ‘honourable’ people, ritual barriers were completely absent; but such barriers belong to the basis of caste differences’.⁹⁰ ‘Nowhere are endogamy and the exclusion of commensalism more rigidly observed than by the occupational castes, and this is by no means true only of the interrelation

of high and low castes. Impure castes shun infectious contact with non-members as rigidly as high castes. This may be taken as a conclusive proof of the fact that mutual exclusiveness was predominantly caused, not by social, but by ritualistic factors based on the quality of many of these castes as ancient guest or pariah people.’⁹¹

All the above facts emphasize that the foundation on which the super-structure of injunctions against inter-caste marriages, inter-caste commensalism, inter-caste contact, pollution, etc., rested was the same. Ritual barriers or magical distance between castes in their mutual relationships (whether it applies to intercaste marriages, inter-caste commensalism, various notions about pollution or to the stigma attached to certain occupations) is a fundamental basis of the caste. ‘The caste order is orientated religiously and ritually to a degree not even partially attained elsewhere.’⁹² ‘Complete fraternization of castes has been and is impossible because it is one of the constitutive principles of the castes that there should be atleast ritually inviolable barriers against complete commensalism among different castes.’⁹³

ii) Restrictions in other societies

Another important point to be borne in mind is that caste restrictions on marriages are not the only restrictions current on marriages between exclusive groups. Individual and group prejudices against marriages, based on considerations of various kinds (viz., health, beauty, colour, race, class, etc.) exist in societies where there are no castes. In other words, caste endogamy is superimposed on prejudices about marriages between mutually exclusive groups common to non-caste societies as well. This leads to two corollaries. First, the problem of restrictions on marriages between exclusive groups or classes is not solved by the undoing of the caste endogamy. Secondly, the problem of removing prejudices regarding marriages, as it is in non-caste societies, is hard enough to solve. Because, in view of the very personal nature of the marriage relations and the human prejudices involved, no positive regulations can be prescribed in this field. Except for marriage restrictions imposed by the caste system, few societies have tended to lay down positive laws governing marriages between different social groups or

classes. No wonder the Plato's suggestion in this regard always remained as the odd ramblings of a philosopher's mind; and the attempt in Rome to regulate marriages through the Theodosian Code failed miserably. For the same reasons, the racial problem between the Whites and the Negroes in the USA, or elsewhere, continues to be intractable. The super-imposition of caste endogamy on the other prejudices regarding marriages made the problem doubly complicated.

iii) The Approach of the Sikh Movement

Gurus' stand on the issue is very clear. When the Muktas (the select band of Sikhs in the congregation of Guru Gobind Singh at Anandpur who were given the honorific title for being foremost in living upto the ideals of Sikhism) advocated inter-caste marriages, the other Sikhs openly expressed their inability to follow this line. The matter was represented to the Guru himself. The Guru indicated that the advice of the Muktas should be followed. He said, 'The four castes are one brotherhood. The Guru's relationship to the four castes is common (i.e. equal). There is no doubt about it... Muktas are my own life. What they do is acceptable.'⁹⁴

'Caste is probably what Professor Bartlett would call one of the 'hard points' of Hindu culture, and any attempt to modify it by a direct attack on it is likely to provoke resistance and discord, and reformers will need to aim at some 'soft point', some other feature of the culture, that is, through which the 'hard point' can ultimately be circumvented and isolated.⁹⁵ It is probably on this account that, 'In regard to the matter of the right to enter Hindu temples, the exterior castes were advised by Mr. Gandhi not to attempt to gain entry, as God resides in their breasts.'⁹⁶ If this cautious approach was necessary in the twentieth century, it was much more so in the times of the Sikh Gurus. They had to avoid taking steps that might affect adversely the very objectives of the movement. They were not idle dreamers interested only in the postulation and declaration of a utopian stand. They could not afford to sit in isolation tied to an abstract maxim. They were the leaders of a movement. Although they never swerved for a moment from their objectives, and even paid with their lives for not doing so, they had to weigh beforehand the feasibility of

each and every step they took in the light of its likely consequences on the course of the movement as a whole. As leaders keen to achieve practical results, they were aware of the necessity not only of carrying their followers with them, atleast a majority of them, but also of ensuring their zealous participation. Evidently, they would not like to take such steps as might side-track the main problems.

There were open rifts in Sikh ranks at different places between those who wanted to stick to the old rite of Bhadan (cutting of the hair of the child at a certain stage of his life) and those who wanted to give it up following the Guru's injunction not to shave.⁹⁷ Where differences could crop up on such a minor issue, the Gurus could not risk the future of the movement by insisting on inter-caste marriages.

The abolition of the caste was not the only goal of the Sikh movement. It had also to fight the religious and political oppression of the rulers. In fact, the pursuit of this objective became more urgent especially when the Mughal rulers launched a frontal attack to convert the Hindus to Islam. The Sikh movement depended for all its recruitment to its ranks entirely on elements drawn from the caste society. It could not afford to cut itself off completely from the base of its recruitment. By doing so, none of the three social objectives of the movement would have been furthered. Neither would it have succeeded in building a society outside the caste order; nor could it have successfully challenged the religious and political domination, or captured political power for the masses.

It is in this context that the anti-caste stance of the Sikh Gurus and the Sikh movement has ever cared to adopt the issue of inter-class marriages as its plank. They know the human prejudices regarding marriages would automatically disappear with the levelling up of class differences. Similarly, the Gurus attacked the very fundamentals of the caste, i.e. caste-status consciousness and the ritualistic barriers between the castes. They hoped that caste endogamy would disappear with the disappearance of caste-status consciousness and these ritualistic barriers. They did not want to side-track the movement from the comparatively urgent problem of meeting the political challenge.

Secondly, as we have said, the Gurus did not want to cut off, as far as possible, the movement from the base of its recruitment. Two instances would amplify the point we want to stress. It was Guru Nanak who started the institution of Langar where people of all castes and creeds dined together. It was a very big step towards breaking the caste ritualistic barriers. But, it was Guru Amardas who made it a rule that no body could see him unless he had dined at the Langar. Possibly this could not be done all at once in the beginning, because it required time to educate and influence the people in overcoming the ritual or taboo by which one could not eat 'in the sight of people not belonging to one's caste'. In the famine of 1866 in Bengal, when people were forced by starvation to eat in the public soup kitchens opened by the Government, 'they made certain that often a sort of symbolic *chambre separee* has created for each caste by means of chalk lines drawn around the tables and similar devices.'¹⁰¹

Again, Guru Gobind Singh himself took away the *Janeo* of Alim Singh when he felt it necessary to prevent him from reverting to the caste society.¹⁰² But, the same Guru advised his Sikhs not to insist on anybody wearing *Janeo*,¹⁰³ nor coerce

* (Indubhusan writes, "As we have already seen, the Langars of the Gurus knew no caste distinctions, but this cannot be said to prove anything, this way or the other, as examples of relaxation of caste rules regarding sacred food distributed from a public sanctuary are to be found even among the most orthodox of Hindus",⁹⁸ The sacred food of the Sikhs is *Karah Prasad* and not the food of the langar. It is recorded in the *Guru Granth* that the wife of Guru Angad used to run the common kitchen. The word used is *Rasoi* (kitchen where meals are prepared). Guru Amar Das used to hold his religious congregations from early in the morning and would at noon 'lead his following (*Sangat*) to the Langar',⁹⁹ i.e. at a different place from that where the religious congregation was held. To this day Langars are attached to the *Gurdwaras*, but are not a part of the *Gurdwara* proper. Whereas *Karah Parsad* is offered in the *Gurdwara*, food is served in the Langar. The original text makes it quite clear that Guru Amardas would refuse to see a man who did not take food in the Langar; the Guru showed himself to him. He who did not partake food due to caste prejudices; he was not able to see the Guru.'¹⁰⁰ Indubhusan's observation is, thus, not correct factually)

anyone to forgo it.* The same was the Guru's approach regarding inter-caste marriages. While he approved of the proposal of the Muktas, he did not prescribe or insist on inter-caste marriages, leaving it to the Sikhs to follow it on their own.

3. The Status of Women

The Sikh movement had comprehensive egalitarian objectives. As such, raising the status of women formed an essential part of its programme. The caste ideology had assigned to women, including those of the upper castes, a low social position. In some respects they were bracketed with the Sudras. Guru Nanak declared, "Why call her bad from whom are born kings?"¹⁰⁴ Guru Amar Das abolished the customs of Purdah and Satti;¹⁰⁵ and of the twenty-two manjis, dioceses or preaching-districts, set up by him, some of them were headed by women.^{105a} The mother of Jassa Singh, the supreme leader of the Sikhs at one time, was a religious preacher.^{105b} Sukha Singh, who later became the commander hero in the battle of Chota Ghalu Ghara, was ostracized for some time by the Khalsa, because he or his wife were suspected of having committed infanticide and thereby having violated the traditional custom of the Khalsa.¹⁰⁶ The status of women raised by the movement is reflected by the fact that they participated in the revolutionary struggle on equal terms with men. It was Mai Bhago who rallied the deserters from Anandpur and led them in the battle of Mukatsar. ^{108a} In the period of guerilla warfare, Sikh women were imprisoned and subjected to hard labour, but they did not forsake their faith.^{108b} Sada Kaur, wife of Gurbakhsh Singh ruled the area which was under the control of Kannahya Misal. She led her armies in battle,¹⁰⁹ and Ranjit Singh owed his success, in his initial struggle for supremacy against the rival Misals, in no small measure to her political acumen and military help. Ahmed Shah Batalvi has given more instances where women took a leading part in the political and military activities of the Misals,¹¹⁰ 'Rani Rajinder Kaur was one of the most remarkable women of the age. She possessed all the virtues which men pretend their own — courage, perseverance and sagacity.'¹¹¹ Sahib Kaur was made the Chief Minister of Patiala in 1793. She refused to leave the battlefield when pressed by the Marathas near Ambala and with a drawn sword rallied her troops to repulse the enemy.¹¹² Similarly, Aus Kaur was placed at the head of the administration of Patiala and she conducted

the affairs of that state with conspicuous success.¹¹³ George Thomas writes in his memoirs (p. 75) 'Instances indeed have not infrequently occurred in which they (Sikh women) have actually taken up arms to defend their habitations, from the desultory attacks of the enemy, and throughout the contest behaved themselves with an intrepidity of spirit, highly praiseworthy.'